

5. Map of Rakhine State Showing Locations of Internal Refugee Camps (2015)[65]

For those still living in the towns, the situation keeps getting worse. The UN's Special Rapporteur noted that he had

> again visited Aung Mingalar, the only remaining Muslim neighbourhood in Sittwe, which he described as a ghetto. In Aung Mingalar ward, he heard from residents that the population had fallen by around 1,600 compared to his August visit. Many had left to risk their lives on rickety boats to reach neighbouring countries, where those who survived the journey were subjected to further human rights violations, including human trafficking.[66]

The isolation of the Rohingyas from the rest of Burmese society only fuels Buddhist suspicions—as such isolation often does. Traditionally, the Islamic community in Myanmar was open and active beyond its own members, for example running the Muslim Free Hospital in Rangoon.[67] But as they have become isolated, they are becoming more and more 'foreign' to the rest of the people of Myanmar. After all, the less contact you have with the Rohingyas, the less reason you have to disbelieve the extremist nationalist claims that they are 'preparing for Jihad' or any other such nonsense. You simply have no way of knowing any better. This separation of communities means a breakdown in empathy between the two groups, but also leads to ignorance on what each community needs and desires. Thus, you would never suspect a neighbour you know well of plotting for jihad. But one you never have the opportunity to speak to… who knows what he is plotting! Conversely, the Rohingyas have been given more than enough reasons to distrust their Rakhine neighbours. Unfortunately, such a cycle of distrust, once established, can take on a life of its own. And we have already seen some of the consequences of that. But things can still get a lot worse.

For those Rohingyas who stay in Rakhine, the reality is de facto imprisonment in the refugee camps, with no access to health or education.[68] Many Rakhine politicians are aiming to ensure that the refugee camps to which the Rohingyas fled in 2012 and 2013 remain their permanent homes,[69] if they cannot actually force them from Myanmar. More than this, they intend to force those Rohingyas still living in villages into the camps. Once there, they are denied the means to earn a living other than through